

Q What are the top features of Xiaomi MIUI that you think are lacking in other devices?

First of all, we have a dramatically simplified UI for the average person; so it feels simpler than anything else in the market right now.

Second, it is very customisable and is really appealing to our customers. We have thousands of themes that can completely change the experience, not just the wall paper or the lock screen. From very detailed to very minimalistic designs, from cartoonist styles to cultural statements and on to other things, there is a huge list of options to choose from.

Third, I would say that there's customisation for power users as well. You can change a lot of things in the system. You can control permissions on apps, and you can decide which apps are allowed to run in the background. There is a lot you can do to fine tune the performance of your device if you choose to. For example, you can decide which apps are allowed to access the 3G network. So I can say that out of the 45 apps that I have running on my phone, the only ones that are allowed to use 3G are WhatsApp, Hike, my email and my browser. I don't want any of the other apps that are running on this phone to be allowed to access 3G at all, which I won't know about and which may use bandwidth that I am paying for. It is a very simple menu. Like checkboxes, it lets you choose the apps that you want to allow 3G access to. So if you care about how much bandwidth you are consuming and presently control that by turning 3G on and off (which people do all the time), now you can allow 3G access only to messaging apps like WhatsApp or Hike that use almost no bandwidth at all. Those are the apps that you're all the time connected to because if someone sends you a message, you want to get it as soon as possible.

Fourth, we have added a number of features to the core apps that make them more interesting. These include in-call features that allow users to take notes during a phone call, the ability to record a phone call and a bunch of other things. So it is not the dialler app alone, but also dozens of features all around the OS like turning on the flash light from the lock screen, having a private messaging inbox and a whole lot of other features.

Fifth, on your text inbox, you can pin a person to the top—if there is really someone who matters to you and you always want to have their messages on the top. You can decide at what time an SMS needs to be sent out. You can compose a message saying, "I want this message to go out at 7 p.m.," because maybe you're going to be asleep, for example, but still want that message to go out.

Then there are little things like, if you fire up the camera app and point the camera towards the QR code, it just automatically recognises it. You don't have to download a special app just to recognise the QR codes. If you are connected to a Wi-Fi network with your Mi phone,

you may want to share this Wi-Fi network with someone else. So, you just go into the Wi-Fi wing and say, "Share this connection," and the phone will then share a QR code. The person you want to share your Wi-Fi connection with can just scan this QR code and immediately get connected to the network without having to enter a password. So lots and lots of little things like that add up to a pretty delightful experience.

Q After MIUI from Xiaomi, Panasonic has launched its own UI and Xolo has launched HIVE. So do you think the war has now shifted to the UI level?

I think it would be an injustice to say that our operating system MIUI is just another UI like Android because it is so much more than that. We have had a team of 500 engineers working on our operating systems for the last four years, so it is not just a re-skinning of Android. It is much, much more significant effort. I can spend five hours with you just explaining the features of MIUI. I don't think there are many companies out there that have as significant a software effort that has been on for as long a time, as we have. So while I haven't looked at these operating systems that you are talking about closely, my instinct is that they are not as profoundly different and well founded as MIUI.

Q What are your plans to reach out to the developers?

From a development perspective, first and foremost, we are very Android compliant. All of our builds, before OTA, go to Google for approval, like every other OEM out there. We are focused on Android APIs. We are not building new APIs. We believe that doing so would create fragmentation. It's kind of not ideal and goes against the ecosystem. So, from our point of view, we see developers as our early adopters. They are the people who we think are best equipped to try our products. We see developers as the first people that we take our devices to try out. That's primarily how we view the developer community.

There are some interesting twists out there as well. For instance, we are the first company to make a Tegra K1 tablet. So, already, MiPad is being used by game developers as the reference development platform for K1 game tabs. This is one of the few ways in which we get in touch with the developers and work with them.

Q How do you want to involve the Indian developer community, considering the fact that it is one of the largest in the world?

First of all, we are looking to hire developers here. We are looking to build a software engineering team in India, and in Bengaluru, to be precise—where we are headquartered. So that is the first and the most important step for us. The second angle is MIUI. It's not an open source operating system, but it is an open operating system that is based on Android. A lot of the actual code is closed, but it's open